Robby had barely settled into the rhythm of summer at the farm when Steve and Sarah pulled him aside with news that made his stomach tighten.

“You got a slot,” Steve said, a rare grin tugging at his lips. “First ship. The one leaving Silvercreek. Only two hundred spots, out of… well, the entire town.”

Robby stared. Silvercreek was home to thousands, yet here he was, officially chosen for a place on the first vessel. The weight of it pressed on him. Not fear, exactly, but the sharp thrill of opportunity.

“First ship?” he repeated, trying to wrap his head around it. “But… how?”

“Your work with Tom, the house, your problem-solving. They’ve been keeping tabs,” Sarah explained. “They want you as an apprentice engineer. You’ll train under a couple of the older crew. Once a week, you’re at the shipyard, learning, helping, sometimes building. It’s… a big deal, kid.”

Robby nodded slowly, heart hammering. Being on a ship was nothing like tending fields or tinkering under the canopy of his future workshop. These were vessels meant to carry people through space, a failure here didn’t just mean broken equipment, it could mean lives at risk.

The first trip to the shipyard was breathtaking. The massive hulls were beginning to rise above the docks like half-formed giants, cranes swung enormous parts into place, and the smell of oil, hot metal, and welding arcs hung heavy in the air. Sparks danced across the shadows of the cavernous space as Robby followed the engineers up scaffolding and around work bays.

He met the team, older engineers, hands scarred and blackened from decades of work. Their eyes measured him in seconds: sharp, precise, calculating.

“Kid,” said a tall man with grease under his fingernails, voice rough like gravel, “you drop a bolt in the wrong place here, and you won’t just ruin a machine, you could ruin lives. You understand?”

“I do,” Robby said, nodding. The words felt small against the weight of the reality he’d just stepped into.

He started with small tasks: measuring components, tracking tolerances, running tools, double-checking connections. At first, the world was overwhelming. His instincts were sharp, but translating theory into the scale of a full ship was harder than he imagined. A dropped wrench clanged across the metal deck, drawing a few groans and one amused chuckle from the senior engineers.

Slowly, they let him take on more. They allowed small mistakes in controlled situations, teaching him the consequences of carelessness. Every misaligned pipe, every misread gauge, every minor oversight reminded him that this was serious work, and that responsibility couldn’t be faked.

By the end of the first month, Robby was no longer just the quiet boy who built his own house and tamed a tractor. He was an apprentice, recognized, watched, and tested in ways that mattered. Engineering was becoming more than skill, it was identity. He belonged to the shipyard, to the tools, to the machines that could carry people far beyond the world he’d always known.

“This will be my world,” he whispered, almost reverently. “And I have to earn my place in it.”

Robby quickly realized that being selected for the first ship wasn’t a reward, it was a privilege. One that could be taken, as several had slid back to the second ship already after just a couple of months.

The first few weeks at the shipyard were exhilarating. He ran tools, measured beams, checked circuits, and tracked tolerances. He could follow instructions, even improve minor inefficiencies, and his knack for spatial reasoning impressed the senior engineers. But experience has a way of teaching lessons that textbooks cannot.

It happened on a Tuesday. Robby had been assigned to help install the fuel line for one of the ship’s auxiliary engines. The line was long, thick, and stubborn, snaking across the hull like a living thing. He measured the bends, marked the clamps, and began fitting sections together, thinking he’d calculated everything perfectly.

“Careful with that end,” the senior engineer, Griggs, a man with a permanent crease in his forehead, warned. “If that clamp slips, it’ll leak under pressure. You don’t want a spray of hydrazine in your face.”

Robby nodded, keeping his hands steady. He had done this hundreds of times on smaller engines and generators. He knew the theory, knew the math.

And then it happened. A clamp slipped.

Not catastrophically, yet, but enough that a small hiss of water escaped, coating a section of the hull in a slick mist. Everyone froze. Griggs barked a warning and yanked the line into place before the leak could spread. Robby stepped back, stomach sinking.

“Do you understand why that happened?” Griggs asked, his voice low but sharp.

Robby nodded, cheeks burning. “I… misjudged the pressure differential and the tolerance of the clamp under load. I calculated it right, but I didn’t account for the flex in the hull.”

“Exactly,” Griggs said. “Theory is theory, Engineering is reality. You have to be able to visualize how reality bends it more than just understanding the math behind it. That’s also why we use water to do these tests.”

For the next few hours, Robby stayed under close supervision, rechecking every joint, every connection he had touched. He cleaned the spill, replaced the clamps, and re-verified the alignment. His hands were sore, his clothes stained, but he didn’t complain. Every mistake etched itself into memory like a warning carved in metal.

The next week, a similar lesson came in the form of a misaligned conduit. Robby had run a wiring harness too close to a vent. Heat buildup could have fried the insulation over time. He hadn’t noticed it until the senior engineer did a full inspection.

“You need to see the system as a whole,” she said. “Every component affects every other. A tiny mistake in one section can cascade through the entire vessel. Hundreds of people will rely on this ship functioning perfectly. Do you get that?”

“I do,” Robby said, swallowing the lump in his throat.

But he didn’t truly understand until later that afternoon. He was helping to mount the life-support manifolds when he misread a pressure gauge. The manifold would have functioned poorly, reducing oxygen flow in the crew quarters by just enough to make people sluggish and dizzy over time. The engineer caught it and fixed it immediately, but the reality sank in: mistakes weren’t just theoretical, they could have real, human consequences.

Robby spent that night walking the scaffolding, looking at the massive hull, thinking. Every bolt, every joint, every gauge, every pipe was a tiny responsibility. Every error, no matter how small, had a ripple effect. It wasn’t enough to know the math; he had to feel it, anticipate it, internalize it.

The lessons kept coming. Sometimes he worked for hours, only to have a senior engineer shake their head and say, “No, that alignment is off. Measure again.” Sometimes he had to dismantle and rebuild entire sections because he had cut a bracket too short or misread a schematic. The work was humbling, exhausting, and unforgiving, but it also transformed him.

By midsummer, Robby had earned a quiet respect. He was no longer the smart kid who just built his own house. He could read schematics, anticipate stress points, and notice tolerances before most others else did. His hands were scarred and calloused, his forearms lined with grease and welding burns, but he carried himself with the confidence of someone who had learned through trial, error, and correction.

He still made mistakes, he would always make mistakes, but he had learned the critical difference: to own them, fix them, and ensure they never repeated. Mistakes weren’t failures; they were tuition paid in sweat, blood, and steel. And in that sense, Robby was learning faster than anyone else in the yard.

Late one evening, after the hull was quiet and the lights dimmed, he leaned against a railing and looked out over the water near Silvercreek. The town sprawled below, hundreds of lights twinkling, thousands of lives going on. And he was part of the select few chosen for the first ship, for the chance to leave and see beyond.

He let his hands fall into his pockets, muscles sore but steady. Engineering was becoming more than a skill, more than a hobby, more than a way to survive. It was responsibility, it was identity, and it was the first thread weaving him into a world bigger than the one he had grown up in.

And as he walked back toward the scaffolding, ready to double-check another section, he realized something else: he was ready for it.

By the fall, Robby had settled into a rhythm that felt both exhausting and natural. Shipyard visits were no longer a novelty, they were part of his week, a thread woven into his life. He could walk among the massive hulls, makeshift cranes swinging enormous components overhead, and feel like he belonged. Not just because he had hands that could handle tools or a mind that could calculate tolerances on the fly, but because he had begun to *carry responsibility*, the kind that didn’t let him turn away.

One evening, as the sun slanted low across the scaffolding, Robby was assigned to a small, but critical, task: overseeing the installation of the oxygen scrubbers in the first crew compartment. He was the lead on it. Senior engineers had shown him the theory, guided him through the schematics, and then stepped back, trusting him to execute. Griggs was there leaning against a rail smoking his pipe watching Robby work.

Laura arrived at the edge of the deck shortly after, bundled against the early fall chill, a small thermos in hand. “I thought you might need some caffeine,” she said, smiling. “And maybe a little moral support with Griggs here impersonating a helicopter.”

Griggs took a drag from his pipe, smiled, and exhaled a slow stream of smoke into the outside air.

Robby gave her a hug and took a long pull from the cup of coffee letting out a satisfied gasp at the end. Robby felt a warmth he didn’t have words for that didn’t come from the coffee. While sipping he visually inspected his progress so far.

Halfway through, a misalignment in one of the pipes caught his eye. It wasn’t obvious at first, just a millimeter off, but in a closed system like this, millimeters could matter. He froze for a heartbeat. Then, slowly, he recalculated, repositioned the bracket, and re-secured the pipe.

Griggs clapped him on the shoulder. “That’s what I’m talking about. Sometimes you need to step back to see the issue. I was waiting to see if you would catch that.”

Robby shrugged, trying not to grin. “You’ve been a good teacher Mr Griggs.”

Even as the compartment took shape, Robby noticed the little things that nobody told him mattered. The way the sunlight hit the control panels, the slight flex in the bulkheads as the hull shifted, the tension in a cable that could fray if tightened too much. Engineering wasn’t just about assembling parts, it was about anticipating every variable, taking responsibility for the unseen, and caring enough to *notice*.

Back at home, evenings were quieter. He’d return covered in grease and dust, but he couldn’t shake the rhythm of responsibility. He helped Steve and Sarah check solar panels on his house, recalibrated the tractor’s electric motor, or explained some clever fix he’d learned at the shipyard to Laura.

The trailer was unusually full for a weeknight. Sarah had insisted on a “proper” movie night, dragging Robby, Laura, Steve, and Laura’s dad along. Blankets were spread on the floor, chairs were rearranged, and the omnipad was hooked up to the trailer’s projector.

“I’ve been waiting for this all week,” Sarah said, bouncing slightly on the balls of her feet. “You *have* to see it, the special effects alone are worth it. And the story! Classic human ingenuity in space. ‘Starlight Horizon,’ 2037 cut. Pre-AI era. Everything filmed with real actors!”

Steve and Laura’s dad exchanged glances. Neither had particularly wanted to be here. “Real actors,” Steve muttered, folding his arms. “Sounds like a waste of time. AI’s fine. Less drama, less whining.”

“Less charm, you mean,” Sarah shot back, rolling her eyes. “Real stunts, real danger. No AI can fake this kind of tension.”

Laura nudged Robby, whispering, “You don’t have to pick sides.”

Robby shrugged. He had no horse in this race. He was more interested in seeing what Sarah got so worked up.

The lights dimmed, the projector flickered, and the opening scene crept across the screen. Ships leapt from one system to another, engines flaring, laser fire slicing the darkness. Sarah's grin was infectious. She leaned forward in her seat, whispering plot points and little trivia about how each shot had been done.

Robby watched, fascinated by both the movie and Sarah's excitement. Laura curled up next to him with a small blanket draped over her shoulders, eyes wide, fingers tapping gently against her knees. Even Laura's dad was leaning forward slightly, though he tried to look disinterested. Steve sat at the back, arms crossed, muttering occasional criticisms under his breath.

Halfway through, a tense sequence came, a crew had to manually reroute power through a damaged engine, sparks flying and alarms blaring. Robby's pulse picked up, partly from the scene, partly from remembering his own early mistakes on the ship. He glanced at Sarah, who was practically vibrating with enthusiasm.

"You'd love this part," she whispered, nudging him. "That tension? That's real filmmaking. Every decision matters. Like… like engineering in real life."

Robby grinned. "Yeah… I can see that."

Laura laughed softly, resting her head lightly against his shoulder. "You *do* get it, don't you?"

Steve shook his head from the back. "Too much melodrama. If the ship's going to blow up, I want it grounded in reality, not actors screaming. And always managing to save the day with one second left on the clock."

Sarah scowled, elbowing Steve in the ribs. "Some of us enjoy *storytelling*, Steve. Try it sometime."

Laura's dad just shook his head, muttering about "kids these days." But Robby noticed a tiny smile tugging at his lips. He liked seeing the old man's reactions, even if he pretended not to care.

By the end of the movie, the trailer was quiet except for Sarah's occasional commentary and the hum of the projector. Robby leaned back, relaxed in a way he rarely allowed himself. The feeling of home, the weekly tasks at the shipyard, even the farm, the weight of responsibility lifted away for a moment. He was just another kid enjoying a story snuggling with his girlfriend.

"Same time next week?" Sarah asked, glancing at him with a hopeful grin.

Robby chuckled. "Sure. But only if you promise to lecture Steve again."

"Deal," she said.

Steve muttered from the back, "I'm bringing popcorn next time. Traded for some, got my hands on some real butter and salt. You'll see, it makes all the difference."